

million across three rounds, AllHome around \$40 million across equity and debt, and OffBeat ₹100 crore in seed funding. Some of them are still pre-revenue and may not succeed. Still, venture capitalists are committing far larger cheques, and much earlier, than they typically would to first-time founders.

“These new businesses are riskier than consumer businesses, but investors are willing to back them because they have proven themselves once,” says Meena. It helps that the founders themselves have skin in the game, and what investors are really backing is a decade or more of pattern recognition.

PharmEasy’s Sheth says that

a refined version of the models that worked for us at PharmEasy.” Skill and execution are good but incomplete without perspective. Bhalerao says years spent building consumer businesses gave founders an unusually close view of how Indian consumers evolved. They watched incomes rise, brands premiumise and purchasing behaviour change.

“Let’s say you built a consumer electronics business. Years of working with manufacturers, branding agencies, packaging firms and creators have become a resource that can be deployed across multiple businesses,” says Bhalerao.

That accumulated knowledge is already being put to work.

computing in every hand. AI is now lowering the cost of creation itself.

“Earlier, you had an idea but thought the technology wasn’t ready for you to build it,” says Meena. “Now, a lot of spaces have opened because of AI. It has also fast-tracked the entire process.”

AI has compressed the journey from an idea to a working product. Data analysis has become dramatically cheaper, early versions of products can be built and tested far more quickly, and workflows ranging from demand forecasting and marketing campaigns to brand creatives and legal documentation can now move from a blank page to a workable first draft in a fraction of the time they once took.

Bhalerao likens AI to a “Day Zero employee,” a chief of staff that helps founders organise years of accumulated knowledge into repeatable systems. What once required months of sifting through presentations, customer feedback, operating manuals and internal documents can increasingly be done in hours.

“AI won’t solve for motivation or insight, but the cold-start problem has practically been reduced to zero,” he says. “Building a start-up from zero to one has become way more efficient.”

For entrepreneurs building again, the timing is especially significant. They are arriving at a moment when years of operating experience coincide with technologies that dramatically lower the cost of building while opening entirely new categories of business.

The last generation of internet start-ups proved India could build consumer internet companies at scale. The next generation is asking a more ambitious question: what else can India build? **BT**

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even though AllHome seems like unfamiliar territory, the operating model behind the new venture is the same PharmEasy. “PharmEasy let us build B2C, B2B, B2B2C, a large diagnostics platform and SaaS businesses under one roof,” says Sheth. “It teaches you scale, and it teaches you what actually works across very different business types.”

Three lessons carried directly into AllHome: integrating acquisitions, using technology and automation to improve operations, and managing an organisation that grew to thousands of employees. AllHome, he says, is “essentially

Mamaearth founders Ghazal and Varun Alagh have taken stakes in younger consumer brands, bringing operating experience alongside capital. Mukesh Bansal set up Meraki Labs, a venture studio focused on incubating AI and deep-tech start-ups, in 2020, on the cusp of what would become the decade’s defining technological shift.

ROLE OF AI

Each era of entrepreneurship begins with a technological shift that changes the economics of building. The internet lowered the cost of distribution. Smartphones lowered the cost of access by putting